

PROGRAMME PROPOSAL

Reflective Group Counselling & Mindfulness

A 6–8 session facilitated group programme for emotional awareness, self-understanding and greater choice in how we respond.

Understanding what sits underneath the pattern

People often already know what they are “supposed” to do differently. Knowing is not always enough.

A person may know they should not lose their temper, return to a substance, shut people out or repeat a relationship pattern that hurts them. The harder question is what happens *inside* them just before that behaviour takes over.

This programme works from lived experience first. Sessions use conversation, guided reflection, simple experiential exercises and group process to help participants recognise the feelings, needs and survival strategies underneath familiar patterns.

Mindfulness is introduced where it becomes useful. Not as a lecture and not as an abstract idea, but as a practical way of noticing what is happening in the body, breath, emotions and urges before they become an automatic action.

The aim is to create a little more space between *what I feel* and *what I do next*.

Designed for real settings. The programme can be adapted for people navigating recovery, housing instability, family disruption, social exclusion, community violence, difficult relationships or other significant life pressures. The language stays direct, human and accessible.

Experience first. Understanding second. Practice where it matters.

The group is structured, but not taught like a classroom.

1

Arrive & settle

A short grounding or breathing practice helps the group arrive and become present.

2

Explore a real theme

A story, question, guided reflection or exercise opens a theme that participants can recognise in their own lives.

3

Share & make sense together

Participants speak, listen and begin noticing connections between experience, emotion, relationships and behaviour.

4

Practise a different response

Mindfulness, grounding or reflective skills are introduced around what has actually arisen in the room.

Not a lecture

Psychological ideas are introduced in plain language, only where they help participants understand something they have already experienced.

Not forced disclosure

Participation is invited, never demanded. People are encouraged to work at a pace that is appropriate for them.

Not “just meditation”

Mindfulness is one part of a wider relational process. Its purpose is practical: to notice, stay present and create more choice.

The experience comes first.
The language comes afterwards.

The Child We Carry

Exploring early needs, the ways people learned to protect themselves, and how those patterns can continue into adult life.

The session begins with a gentle guided imagery process that helps participants remember something of what it felt like to be younger.

- What did I need from the people around me?
- What made me feel safe or unsafe?
- Where did I feel seen, loved or protected?
- Where was I disappointed, frightened or left alone?

The reflection gradually returns to the person's life today. Participants are invited to notice whether that younger experience still appears in the way they respond to rejection, loneliness, conflict, craving or intimacy.

The group then has space to share. The aim is not to blame the past, but to understand the story and the way a coping strategy may once have made sense.

For one person, withdrawing may have been safer than depending on others. For another, alcohol or drugs may have become a reliable way of changing an unbearable feeling. Someone else may constantly seek reassurance because being left feels intolerable.

MINDFULNESS IN CONTEXT

Once the pattern becomes visible, participants practise recognising the old feeling when it returns: noticing where it is in the body, breathing with it for a few moments, and asking what is actually needed before automatically doing what they usually do.

The point is not “inner child theory”. The point is helping someone recognise the part of their story that is still acting in the present.

The Masks We Wear

Exploring the faces we learn to show the world, what they protect, and what may be underneath them.

Most people learn to present different versions of themselves in different situations. Sometimes that is necessary.

A person walking through a dangerous area may need to look hard and confident even when they are frightened. Someone who has learned that vulnerability is unsafe may use humour, aggression, indifference or silence as protection.

QUESTIONS THE GROUP MAY EXPLORE

- What do I show when I need to be strong?
- What do I show when I do not trust someone?
- What do I hide?
- Where can I safely take the mask off?

Participants may be invited to name, describe or draw the different “masks” they use, then explore what those masks are protecting.

Behind toughness

there may be fear.

Behind aggression

there may be humiliation or hurt.

Behind humour

there may be embarrassment.

Behind indifference

there may be grief.

Mindfulness is then used to help participants stay present with what has emerged. To notice: *This is sadness. My chest is tight. I want to get away. I can stay for one more breath.*

Feeling something difficult while remaining safe, connected and witnessed can itself become part of the work.

A 6-session core, with two optional extensions

The exact sequence would be shaped with the host organisation. A typical programme could include:

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| 01 | Starting Where We Are
Safety, trust, group agreements and the different ways people learn to cope with difficult feelings or situations. |
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| 02 | The Child We Carry
Early needs, hurt, protection and the patterns that can continue into adult life. |
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| 03 | The Masks We Wear
The identities and protective faces we use to stay safe, and what may sit underneath them. |
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| 04 | Anger, Hurt & Triggers
Slowing down what happens when we feel disrespected, rejected, threatened or overwhelmed. |
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| 05 | Craving, Avoidance & Relief
Understanding what a coping strategy provides, and recognising the need beneath the urge. |
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| 06 | The Moment Before
Recognising body cues, thoughts and urges before action, and practising a different response. |

OPTIONAL 07

Trust, Boundaries & Relationships

How we protect ourselves in relationships, what trust asks of us, and how boundaries can support connection rather than simply distance.

OPTIONAL 08

Carrying It Forward

Integration, personal warning signs, practices that help, sources of support and what each participant wants to take into life beyond the group.

Small capacities that can make a meaningful difference

The programme does not promise a particular clinical outcome. It is designed to strengthen practical capacities participants can use in everyday life.

Recognising what is happening

More awareness of feelings, triggers, body cues and the patterns that tend to follow them.

Putting experience into words

A greater ability to name what is difficult rather than only acting it out, avoiding it or shutting it down.

Creating a pause

Simple grounding and mindfulness skills that can help a person notice an urge before automatically following it.

Feeling less alone

The experience of hearing other people name similar fears, contradictions and struggles can reduce isolation and shame.

Seeing coping with more compassion

Understanding that a behaviour may have developed for a reason, without removing responsibility for what happens next.

Building healthier ways of relating

Over time, the group develops a culture of empathic listening, mutual support, honest communication and respect. Participants practise healthier ways of relating that can be carried into life beyond the group.

Understanding does not excuse harmful behaviour. It gives us a better chance of changing it.

Structured, adaptable and integrated with the organisation's existing work

Typical format

6–8 WEEKLY SESSIONS

75–90 MINUTES

6–12 PARTICIPANTS

CONSISTENT GROUP PREFERRED

Before the group begins, the facilitator meets with the relevant staff member or team to understand the population, current programme, risks, language, culture and what the organisation hopes the group will add.

Where possible, a staff member or social worker who already knows participants is welcome to join the group. This is encouraged, not required.

Continuity with the host team

An initial hand-off into the first session is strongly encouraged. Familiar staff involvement can help participants enter the group with trust and strengthen continuity between what happens in the room and the organisation's wider support.

Working responsibly

- Personal sharing is encouraged but never forced.
- Exercises are not designed to push participants into reliving traumatic experiences.
- Clear boundaries, confidentiality expectations and group agreements are established early.
- Safeguarding, referral and escalation pathways are agreed with the host organisation in advance.
- Sessions can be adjusted where the group's needs, literacy level, culture or current stability call for a different pace.
- The programme complements existing clinical, social-work, addiction or other specialist support rather than replacing it.

A COLLABORATIVE STARTING POINT

The programme is not delivered as a fixed package imposed on every setting. The first step is understanding who will actually be sitting in the room.

08 · FACILITATOR

Michael Kaplan

ASCHP-registered Wellness Counsellor, group facilitator and founder of Sangham.

Michael has more than a decade of experience working with boys and young men through mentoring, group facilitation and counselling, including many years within the Boys to Men community in Cape Town.

His work combines relational counselling, group process and long-term experience with mindfulness and contemplative practice.

A particular focus of his work is translating psychological and contemplative ideas into experiences people can actually use, without requiring academic language or previous meditation experience.

The emphasis is on meeting people where they are, taking their ways of coping seriously, and helping them develop greater awareness and choice.

A limited number of pro-bono programmes are available.

The full 6–8 week cycle is being offered at no cost to a small number of organisations with a group who could benefit. An initial conversation helps us understand participants, support structures and fit.

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